

The Great Migration

Connect the people, places, and changes of the Great Migration, when about six million African Americans moved from the rural South to cities across the country.

? Historical challenge

Between about 1910 and 1970, roughly six million African Americans left the rural South and moved to cities in the North, Midwest, and West — one of the largest movements of people in U.S. history. Who moved, where did they go, and what changed because of it? Map how people, place, and change connect.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Jacob Lawrence: The Migration Series (The Phillips Collection)

PRIMARY SOURCE

Sixty painted panels (1940–41) telling the story of the Great Migration.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What does one panel show about why people moved or what they found?
- How does art help us understand history?

SOURCES 2

The Great Migration – Classroom Materials (Library of Congress)

SECONDARY SOURCE

Background and primary sources on one of the largest internal migrations in U.S. history.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What were two reasons families chose to move north?
- What is one thing that stayed hard even after moving?

SOURCES 3

The Great Migration – African American Heritage (National Archives)

SECONDARY SOURCE

Overview of the two waves of the migration and their effects.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- About how many people moved, and over how many years?
- How were the two waves connected to the world wars?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT

The Great Migration

about 1910–1970

The rural South to Northern, Midwestern, and Western cities

Who?

African American families and workers from the rural South — sharecroppers, farm laborers, and their children

Jacob Lawrence — a young Black painter who told the story in his Migration Series

Robert S. Abbott — editor of the Chicago Defender, which urged people to move north

Pullman porters — Black railroad workers who carried news north and south

Where?

From the South — Mississippi, Alabama, Georgia, Louisiana, and Texas

To the North and Midwest — Chicago, Detroit, New York (Harlem), Pittsburgh, Cleveland

To the West (later wave) — Los Angeles, Oakland, Seattle

Along the railroads — the rail lines were the highways of the migration

What changed?

Community: big new African American neighborhoods grew in Northern and Western cities

Economy: families moved from farm work to paid factory, steel, and railroad jobs

Culture: a burst of art, music, and writing — the Harlem Renaissance, jazz, and blues

Daily life: children attended better-funded schools and adults could vote — but families faced new housing discrimination

The nation's map: the Black population shifted from mostly rural-Southern to urban and nationwide

How were people, place, and change connected?

When millions of families left Southern farms and rode the railroads to cities like Chicago, Detroit, and New York, they built new communities, took new jobs, and created new music and art — changing both their own lives and the whole country.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your three lenses with a partner. Did you connect the same people to the same places and changes?
- Which change do you think mattered most to families who moved? Why?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

About six million African Americans moved north and west in two waves (roughly 1910–1940 and 1940–1970), driven by push factors (Jim Crow segregation, sharecropping debt, racial violence, disenfranchisement) and pull factors (wartime factory jobs, higher wages, better schools, the vote). Railroads and the Chicago Defender helped spread the movement. It reshaped American cities and culture, including the Harlem Renaissance.

Common misconceptions

- The migration was not one sudden event — it built up over decades in two waves.
- Moving north did not end discrimination; families faced redlining and restrictive housing covenants.
- Name Jim Crow and racial violence plainly, but avoid presentism — people made brave choices within the limits of their time.

Vocabulary

migration, push factor, pull factor, Jim Crow, sharecropping, Harlem Renaissance, urbanization, discrimination.

Historical context

In 1910 about 90% of Black Americans lived in the South; by 1970 only about half did. First wave ~1910–1940 (~2 million, WWI jobs); second wave ~1940–1970 (~3 million, WWII defense jobs). Railroads like the Illinois Central carried migrants north.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

In your own words, explain how people, place, and change connect in the Great Migration. Use at least one detail from each lens and one source.